

Critical Incident Report

The ability to critically reflect has been described as a defining characteristic of any professional practice (Schön, 1983; Walsh & Dolan, 2009). Walsh & Dolan (2009, p.139) suggests that when we observe expert teachers and their actions, we miss the “fundamental dimension” of their internal thought process. From the outside, expert teachers seem to instinctively know how to adjust lessons in the face of surprises, for example. While their actions could be studied and reproduced, Nesbit et al. (2004, p.74) explains that the most valuable skill of a great teacher is their “deep understanding of themselves and their students, and of the organisational contexts in which they work”. This deep understanding is something that can be developed through reflection, both in practice and on practice (Schön, 1983). As a pre-service teacher aspiring to be one of those great teachers someday, I hope to develop my critical reflection skills to the best of my ability. Focusing on reflection on action, Walsh & Dolan (2009) advise multiple strategies to promote critical reflection, including keeping a reflective journal and carrying out a critical incident analysis. I aim to carry out a critical incident analysis in this assignment, and will be using the reflective journal that I kept throughout this teaching placement to do so.

In their description of critical reflection, Schön (1983, p.68) has said that its important for a practitioner to allow themselves to feel “surprise, puzzlement, or confusion in a situation which he finds uncertain or unique”. Through reflecting on the prior experiences that have informed their “implicit behaviour”, the practitioner then “carries out an experiment which serves to generate both a new understanding of the phenomenon and a change in the situation” (Schön, 1983, p.63). From this, I can see that it is important to develop a cycle of reflection and action, each informing the other. Using my reflective journal, I have identified a situation that left me feeling uncomfortable and unprepared as a teacher, and I hope to understand this better in order to inform my future practice.

This incident occurred during my Resource Teaching at my DEIS placement school’s After-School Study Program, at the beginning of the year. Students are typically allowed to work together to do their homework and on this day a pair of Leaving Cert boys were working together on their Maths homework. Their conversation would fluctuate between the work at hand, and jokes made to each other. Despite them sometimes talking off-topic, they were still focusing on their work so I let them talk as long as they weren’t too loud. After a few minutes of answering questions about Financial Maths, they started commenting and joking to each

other about their own ethnicity and social class. Using words like “gypsy” and “African”, they didn’t think either of them would be able to use Financial Maths to “fix being poor”, “especially going to this school”. After their quick back-and-forth they refocused on their work, and I chose to ignore their comments as I was worried I would re-ignite their conversation by drawing attention to their comments. I felt out of place, in both my own ethnicity and my educational background. When similar comments happened again, I advised the students that I’d be happy to help them with their Maths but they aren’t permitted to talk to each other anymore as they’re being too loud.

This incident stood out to me as important to reflect on as it prompted me to write multiple questions to myself in my reflective journal: the students discussing topics of racial ethnicity and social class made me feel uncomfortable, why is this? What kind of language is okay in school, am I supposed to intervene if a student draws attention to their own ethnicity? How does that kind of behaviour fit into promoting an inclusive environment? Did I react in the right way?

Upon reflection, I can see that the students discussing their own ethnicity, social class and school in a negative light left me feeling uncomfortable at the thought of speaking up. This uncomfortableness stemmed from a sudden realisation of a stark contrast between my own educational background and that of these students. Although I am a working class student myself, I attended both an Irish-speaking primary and secondary. The schools I attended served a predominantly white, Irish, catholic population of students. In fact, during my time in school I never interacted with a student who wasn’t white and Irish. I can see now that overhearing students discuss their own ethnicity made me feel inadequately prepared to express my opinion on what they were saying, as I’d never even encountered those kinds of topics in during my own school experience. I feel this incident is significant in the context of my place in the education system as a whole. Over the past two decades, the student population of Irish schools has been growing increasingly culturally diverse, especially in DEIS schools (Devine, 2005; Burns, 2015). In contrast, the teaching population in Ireland has been described as homogenous in its high-level of white, Irish teachers and “is less culturally and ethnically diverse than in other OECD countries” (Hyland, 2012, p.10)

Initially, I felt like I dealt with the situation well considering how conflicted I felt at the time. I didn’t feel like it was my place as a white student-teacher, who attended a school where a high-percentage of students progress to third-level education, to tell students who have

different cultural and educational experiences how to feel or act. This led me to feel justified in simply telling the students to stop talking, rather than bring up the topics they were discussing, which I felt they were more experienced in. Upon reflecting on my role as a teacher, as well as trying to understand the point of view of the students, I no longer feel that my reaction was right.

By noting it in my reflective journal, this incident was something that was in the back of my mind as I was engaging with other parts of the course, and certain topics I learnt in my 'Psychology, Sociology and Inclusive Teaching' helped me come to a deeper understanding of it. Regardless of a teacher's background, it's important to promote a positive and inclusive environment for all students. Intercultural education is of growing importance in our education system, and involves not only celebrating and recognising the diversity of students but also challenging negative bias (NCCA, 2006)

The NCCA (2006, p.41) suggest steps for teachers to take in situations where negative situations involving diversity arise. One of the first things they suggest is to take immediate action and not to wait "to see if the behaviour will change on its own". This suggestion has helped me feel more comfortable in my initial response, in the sense that it is a common response for teachers in those situations. The NCCA (2006, p.41) emphasise the importance of challenging negative bias, and emphasise the need to make clear that "certain behaviour or responses are inappropriate". With this in mind, I can see now that my personal values and intentions were not aligned with my actions during this critical incident. As I was listening to the students putting themselves down, I had strong opinions about the importance of a growth mindset, positive self-concepts and self-efficacy and how they relate to academic achievement (Bandura, 1997; Dweck, 1999). These constructive opinions were overshadowed by how I was uncomfortable with intervening, and ultimately lead to inaction. I can see now that by only asking the students to stop talking, and not challenging their comments or engaging with them, it could even be interpreted by the students that I agree with them or that their behaviour was expected. I don't want to be in a situation again where students negative views of themselves go unchallenged, all students deserve to hear positive encouragement and engagement from their teacher, and I feel like that is how I would approach this situation again in the future.

Reflecting on this incident gave me motivation to research further, and after studying the guidelines put forward by the NCCA, I feel much more comfortable with the topic at hand.

Regardless of my own personal background, I understand the value of promoting an inclusive and intercultural environment, challenging negative views of students in favour of promoting positive ones. I expect my future as a teacher will involve similar situations again, but I plan for my response to be different. I now understand the importance of putting theory into action, and feel more excited to do so. My views on this situation have grown from seeing it as a ‘problem’ that I wanted to ignore, to seeing it as an opportunity for both me and the students – an opportunity for me to put valuable theory into practice. Burns (2015) has highlighted a lack of “engagement with and a valuing of diversity” as a challenge for DEIS schools, and I feel like this incident was a missed opportunity where I could have expressed the value of diversity directly to the students. Thanks to this reflection I’ve been able to recognise this, and aspire not to simply ignore similar situations in the future.

Bibliography

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